

Legal Citation Handbook

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I. Introduction

This concise guide addresses citations in Florida briefs and memoranda. For Florida legal documents, apply the following sources in order:

1. Follow the governing court's rules, administrative orders, and filing instructions.
2. Apply Florida Rule of Appellate Procedure 9.800 to Florida materials.
3. For matters not covered by rule 9.800, apply *The Bluebook: A Uniform System of Citation* (22nd ed. 2025).
4. If neither source covers the issue, consult the *Florida Style Manual*.

Vasily Levin's proposed 2026 revision of *The Indigo Book* 2.0 is available at <https://github.com/vasilyslevin/indigobook.github.com/blob/master/versions/indigobook-2.0-rev2026.html>. It is a useful open reference, but it does not displace a controlling court rule or the citation hierarchy above.

This guide contains four working parts:

- **Core Principles:** Rules that apply throughout a document.

- **Step-by-Step Citation Forms:** Forms for cases, statutes, and common secondary sources.
- **Advanced Elements:** Signals, parentheticals, and abbreviations.
- **Recommended Tools and Resources:** References and verification aids.

The examples use Florida authorities unless stated otherwise. In practitioner documents, italicize or underline case names consistently. A citation sentence ends with a period. A citation clause follows the punctuation of the sentence containing it.

II. Core Principles

1. **When to Cite:** Place a citation immediately after the proposition, quotation, or material fact it supports. Use a citation sentence for a complete supporting citation and a citation clause when the citation forms part of a sentence.
2. **Full and Short Forms:** Give a full citation before using a short form. Use a short form only when the reader can identify the authority without ambiguity. Use *Id.* only when the immediately preceding citation contains one authority and the reference remains clear.
3. **Typeface:**

- In briefs and memoranda, italicize or underline case names, short-form case names, and citation signals consistently.
- Use ordinary roman type for reporter information and statutory citations. Do not use large and small capitals in practitioner documents.

4. **Pinpoint Citations:** Provide the page or statutory subdivision supporting the proposition. Bluebook Rule 1.2 generally requires pincites, except for authorities introduced by *see generally*. Florida Rule of Appellate Procedure 9.800 treats Florida case pincites as optional but preferred.
5. **Year:** Cite the version relevant to the proposition. Use the current statutory year for current law and the historical year when discussing an earlier version.

III. Step-by-Step Citation Forms

A. Citing Cases

A reported-case citation includes: (1) case name, (2) volume, (3) reporter, (4) first page, (5) pinpoint, and (6) court and year.

Step-by-Step Process:

1. **Reporter:** Cite published Florida decisions to the Southern Reporter when available.

2. **Name:** Apply Bluebook Rule 10.2 and Table T6.
3. **Court and Year:** Use “Fla.” for the Supreme Court of Florida and “Fla. [ordinal] DCA” for a district court of appeal.
4. **Pinpoint:** Give the page supporting the proposition.
5. **Signal and Parenthetical:** Add them when the relationship or relevance requires explanation.

Case Citation Checklist

Element	Supreme Court example	District court example
1. Name	<i>Jones v. Utica Mut. Ins. Co.</i>	<i>Allstate Ins. Co. v. Greenstein</i>
2. Volume	463	308
3. Reporter	So. 2d	So. 2d
4. First page	1153	561
5. Pinpoint	1156	562
6. Court and year	(Fla. 1985)	(Fla. 3d DCA 1975)

Examples in Context:

- **Citation sentence:** *Jones v. Utica Mutual Insurance Co.*, 463 So. 2d 1153, 1156–57 (Fla. 1985).
- **Textual sentence:** In *Jones v. Utica Mutual Insurance Co.*, 463 So. 2d 1153, 1157 (Fla. 1985), the Supreme Court of Florida held the dog owner liable under section 767.01.

- **Circuit court:** *Whidden v. Francis*, 27 Fla. Supp. 80 (Fla. 11th Cir. Ct. 1966). The Florida Supplement reports selected lower-court decisions.

Short Forms (Bluebook Rule 10.9):

- *Id.* at 1157.
- *Jones*, 463 So. 2d at 1156.

B. Citing Statutes (Florida Statutes)

Stand-alone form: § 767.01, Fla. Stat. (2026).

Step-by-Step Process:

1. **Section:** Include every relevant subsection without internal spaces.
2. **Year:** Use the current version for current law and the applicable year for historical law.
3. **Text:** Spell out the source when it forms part of a sentence.
4. **History:** Add amendment or repeal information only when relevant.

Statute Citation Table

Context	Form	Example
Stand-alone citation	§ [section], Fla. Stat. ([year]).	§ 767.01, Fla. Stat. (2026).
Subsection	§ [section]([subsection]), Fla. Stat. ([year]).	§ 767.04(1), Fla. Stat. (2026).
First textual reference	Section [number], Florida Statutes ([year]),	Section 767.01, Florida Statutes (2026),
Later textual reference	section [number]	section 767.01

Examples in Context:

- **Current statute:** A dog owner may be liable for damage caused by the owner’s dog. § 767.01(1), Fla. Stat. (2026).
- **Quotation:** Section 767.04, Florida Statutes (2026), provides that a dog owner “is liable for damages suffered by persons bitten” under the stated circumstances.

Cite a session law when enactment history matters. Example: Ch. 2025-61, § 2, Laws of Fla.

C. Citing Secondary Sources

- **Books and Periodicals:** Book: Author, *Title* page (edition year). Article: Author, *Title*, volume Journal first page, pinpoint (year).

- **Florida Attorney General Opinions:** Op. Att’y Gen. Fla. 2016-14 (2016).
- **New Source Types:** See Bluebook Rules 18.3, 22, and 23 and proposed Indigo Book Rules R35 through R37 for AI, Tribal Nation, and archival sources.

IV. Advanced Elements

A. Introductory Signals (Bluebook Rule 1.2)

Signals state an authority’s relationship to a proposition. Italicize signals in practitioner citations. Capitalize a signal at the start of a citation sentence and use lowercase in a citation clause.

Step-by-Step Order:

1. Group signals by support, comparison, contradiction, and background.
2. Follow the table’s order within each group.
3. Use semicolons within one signal and a new sentence for a new group.

Signals Table

Family	Signal	Use
Support	No signal	Directly states the proposition.
Support	<i>e.g.</i>	Supplies examples.
Support	<i>accord</i>	Agrees with cited authority.
Support	<i>see</i>	Clearly supports the proposition.
Support	<i>see also</i>	Gives additional support.
Comparison	<i>cf.</i>	Gives analogous support.
Comparison	<i>compare ... with</i>	Uses relevant similarities.
Comparison	<i>contrast ... with</i>	Uses relevant differences.
Contradiction	<i>contra</i>	Directly states the contrary.
Contradiction	<i>but see</i>	Clearly supports the contrary.
Contradiction	<i>but cf.</i>	Gives analogous contrary support.
Background	<i>see generally</i>	Supplies background.

Rule 1.2 requires explanatory parentheticals after *see also*, *cf.*, *compare ... with*, *contrast ... with*, and *see generally*. It generally requires pincites for other citations.

B. Parentheticals (Bluebook Rules 1.2 and 1.5)

Use a brief explanatory parenthetical when relevance is unclear.

Step-by-Step:

1. Begin a summary with a lowercase present participle, such as “holding that.”

2. Use a short statement or a properly capitalized complete quotation when clearer.
3. For modified quotations, Bluebook Rule B5.3 uses “(citation modified).” Proposed Indigo Book Rule R8.2.7 permits “(cleaned up).” Follow the governing source.

Examples:

- *Jones v. Utica Mutual Insurance Co.*, 463 So. 2d 1153, 1157 (Fla. 1985) (holding that an affirmative or aggressive act by the dog was required under the statute then in effect).
- *Knupfer v. Lindblade (In re Dyer)*, 322 F.3d 1178, 1190–91 (9th Cir. 2003) (stating the civil-contempt standard).

C. Abbreviations (Bluebook Tables T6, T7, and T10; Florida Style Manual Section 2)

- **Case Names:** Apply Table T6, including “Co.” for “Company” and “Env’t” for “Environmental.”
- **Reporters:** Use “So. 2d,” “So. 3d,” and “F.4th.” Use “F. App’x” only for decisions published in the discontinued Federal Appendix.
- **Courts:** Use “Fla.” for the Supreme Court of Florida and “Fla. 1st DCA” through “Fla. 6th DCA” for the district courts of appeal.

Abbreviation Examples

Word or form	Abbreviation
Company	Co.
Commission	Comm'n
Employees	Emps.
Employees'	Emps.'
Employee's	Emp.'s
First District Court of Appeal	Fla. 1st DCA

V. Recommended Tools and Resources

Use these resources for concise citation research and verification:

- **The Indigo Book:** Use Vasily Levin's proposed 2026 revision of *The Indigo Book 2.0* at <https://github.com/vasilyslevin/indigobook.github.com/blob/master/versions/indigobook-2.0-rev2026.html>. Confirm court-specific requirements independently.
- **cite.review:** <https://cite.review/> checks citation identity and metadata against public legal sources and can compare a draft's proposition with opinion text. Review every warning and confirm each result against the controlling authority. Do not upload confidential or restricted material without authorization.